SUIT ESTABLISHMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Feel free to disagree with the bidding which is more or less Standard American, not 2-Over-1.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ESTABLISHMENT LESSON

It's great when you have a suit like A K Q J 10 9, six winners just ready to lead out.
But these suits occur only rarely and then usually in the opponent's hands.
So this lesson is about making winners in suits that are not so robust.
This creating of winners is called "establishing" the suit, or perhaps "setting up" the suit.

Establishing by force:

Sometimes the play will be completely obvious, such as this hand.

The contract is 6NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.

♠ K 10 3
♥ K 7 2
♦ Q J 10 9 8
♣ 4 2



♠ A Q 2
♥ A 5 4
♦ K 6 3
♣ A K Q 7

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 8.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit beckons.
Win the ♥ lead, probably with your ♥A, then play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes their ♦A. That is the only trick you will lose since you can easily reach Dummy's remaining ♦ winners.

Ruffing to establish a suit:

Sometimes Dummy has a long suit which would be useful for discards but you have no high cards in the suit to help establish the suit by force. If you're playing a suit contract you may be able to use ruffs to do the work.

Look at an example of this technique.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♥ A K Q then switches to a trump.

Loser count: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

♠ K 4 3
♥ 8 3 2
♦ A K 9 4 2
♣ J 2

Many Declarers will decide the contract depends on the ♣ finesse, so they will pull trumps, get to Dummy and finesse East for the ♣K. And half of the time they will make their contract. Of course the other half of the time they will go down. A more expert Declarer will try to find a plan that doesn't put all her eggs in one basket.



Look at Dummy's ♦ suit. If the defender's ♦s happen to be split 3 - 3 then two winners can be set up by ruffing. But, you have to be careful with your entries. So you win the trump lead in your hand and pull one more trump, making sure you leave the ♠K in Dummy. If the trumps split 3-2 all will be well. If not then you will have to rely on the ♣ finesse. Leave the last trump out for a little while and work on ♦s. Play ♦ A K 2, ruffing the ♦2 with a high trump. IF both defenders follow suit to all three ♦s then the ♦ 9 4 are now winners. Pull the last trump by leading to Dummy's ♠K and discard your ♣ Q 10 on the good ♦s.

♠ A Q J 10 5
♥ J 9 7
♦ 6 3
♣ A Q 10

If it turns out the ♦s do not split 3-3 you will be in dummy with the ♠K and you can take the ♣ finesse.
Played correctly you will make the contract whenever East holds the ♣K but you will also make it when the ♦s split 3-3.
Two chances are definitely better than one.

Ducking to establish a suit:

Here is a nice suit for you and Dummy to have:

♦ A K 9 7 4 2



♦ 6 3

If you are playing a suit contract, say 4♥, you might well establish the suit by ruffing as you did in the last section. But if instead you are playing a notrump contract you will have to establish the suit by a different method.

The "brute force" technique would work just fine with this situation:
The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ A 3
♥ 9 3 5
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ A 2



♠ K 8 5 2
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ K 4 3

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

Needing 2 more winners you will naturally turn to Dummy's ♦ suit. Since there are two black suit Aces in Dummy you don't have a problem with entries so you just bang down the ♦ A K 9. As long as the suit splits 3 - 2 you will establish plenty of extra winners and you will make 6NT with ease.

BUT,

What if Dummy didn't have those two black suit entries???????

The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 3 2
♥ 9 3 2
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ 3 2



♠ A K 8 5
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ A K 4

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

You must find 2 more winners and again, the only hope is Dummy's ♦ suit.
If the suit splits 3 - 2 you can establish 3 winners by playing ♦ A K 9. It won't do you any good though, since you will have zero chance of getting to Dummy to use them.

Try this instead. Win the opening lead in your hand and lead a ♦, playing a small one from Dummy. The defenders will win this trick pretty cheaply, but you don't care. You are hoping that their remaining ♦s are now split 2 - 1, in which case they will fall under Dummy's ♦ A K. And best of all, you still have a small ♦ to lead!

This technique, Ducking, is very useful when Dummy is short (or empty) of entries.

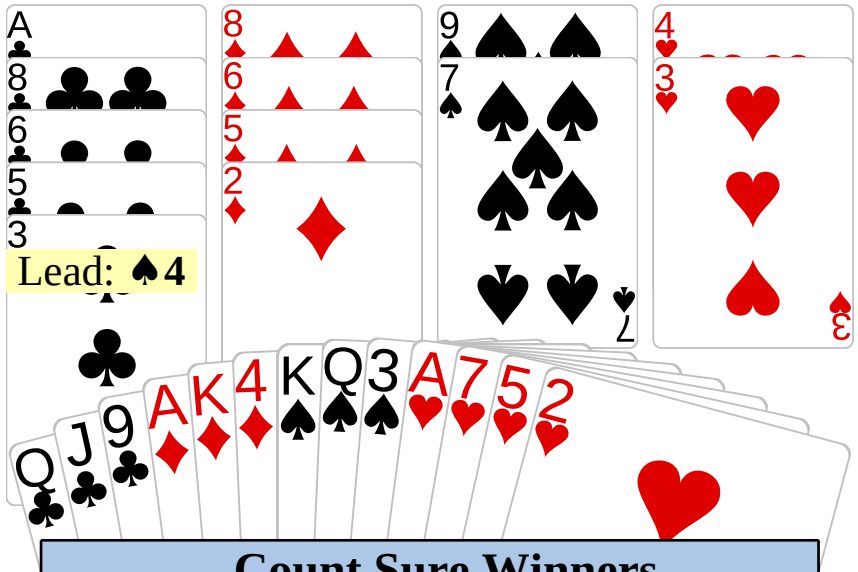
20 Deals are worth more than another 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



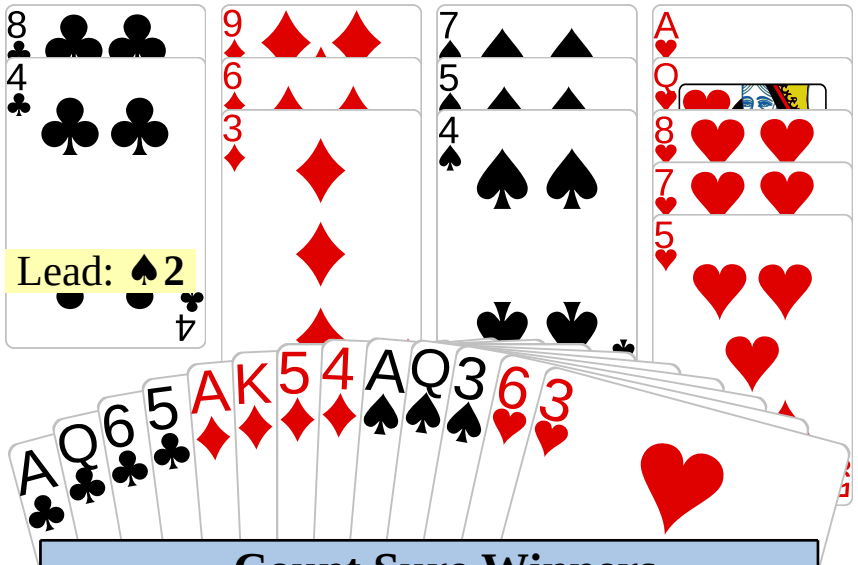
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠4

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠4

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠2

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠6

Board: 6
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠2

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K 5 2 ♥ A K 4 3 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ 9 5	
♠ J 9 7 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ J 9 ♣ J 10 6 2	N W E S	♠ Q 10 6 4 ♥ J 8 2 ♦ K 8 4 ♣ Q 8 3
	♠ 8 3 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A Q 10 6 2 ♣ A K 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠4

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠4, dummy plays the ♠3 and West the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners. They cannot possibly come from ♠s, ♥s, or ♣s since one defender must hold at least 4 cards in each of those suits. So your two extra winners must come from the ♦ suit.

There is no reason to hold up on the ♠ since the ♥ and ♣ suits also have just two stoppers. You win the ♠A.

You best play next is to finesse the ♦10. This may gain a trick by virtue of the finesse if East happens to hold the ♦J, but primarily you are working to establish the ♦ suit. Assume West wins the ♦J and returns a ♠.

Again don't hold up. Take the ♠K and lead another small ♦, finessing with dummy's ♦Q. Happily this time the finesse works, and even more happily both defenders follow suit. That means the rest of the ♦s are good and you make an overtrick.

This was just a normal suit-establishment Deal.

If looked different because of the two finesses you took.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A 8 5
♥ Q 10 9 6
♦ Q J 9
♣ 10 7 4

♠ 9 7
♥ 4 3
♦ 8 6 5 2
♣ A 8 6 5 3



♠ K Q 3
♥ A 7 5 2
♦ A K 4
♣ Q J 9

♠ J 10 6 4 2
♥ K J 8
♦ 10 7 3
♣ K 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	Pass	1♣	Pass
2♣	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠4

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠4. North puts on the ♠A and returns the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

Needing three more winners you are going to have to establish the ♣ suit. You are also going to have to be lucky!

You win the second ♠ and play your ♣Q. South covers with the ♣K. What do you do next?

You **DUCK**. If you take the ♣A now you will never get back to dummy to enjoy those other ♣s. So let South have the ♣K. You win his return, (probably a ♠), and play ♣J, then ♣9 to dummy's ♣A. As long as ♣s split 3-2 you will get the three winners you need.

You were prepared to lose that ♣ finesse to North so you could establish the suit in dummy.

South's play of the ♣K may have made you want to jump up with the ♣A, but you must stick to the original play of ducking one trick.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 5 4 ♥ A Q 8 7 5 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ 8 4	
♠ K 10 8 2 ♥ K 10 4 ♦ 8 7 2 ♣ K J 7	N W E S	♠ J 9 6 ♥ J 9 2 ♦ Q J 10 ♣ 10 9 3 2
	♠ A Q 3 ♥ 6 3 ♦ A K 5 4 ♣ A Q 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	Pass	1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and East puts on the ♠J.

West plays low.

East wins with the ♥9.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

You need three more winners. It is possible your fourth ♦ can be established, but that needs a 3-3 split. It's also possible that the ♣ finesse will work, and also the ♥ finesse. Since you need the ♥ finesse anyway you should go ahead and try to establish the ♥s.

Win the first trick with your ♠Q and play a low ♥, ducking in dummy. East will no doubt win a cheap trick but no matter. When you next gain the lead play your other low ♥ and finesse the ♥Q. Assume this wins (if it doesn't you will be going down for sure). Play the ♥A and if both defenders follow your other 2 ♥s are good and your contract is made.

Ducking the first ♥ and finessing the second could let you wind up with no tricks at all in the ♥ suit.

But, it is your only chance to make the contract.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K Q J 10 ♥ 10 9 ♦ 7 4 3 ♣ K 10 7 2	
♠ 7 4 ♥ A Q 8 6 2 ♦ Q 6 ♣ A 8 4 3	N W E S	♠ 8 6 5 3 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ K J 10 8 5 ♣ Q
	♠ A 9 2 ♥ J 7 3 ♦ A 9 2 ♣ J 9 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♠K

Some pretty agressive bidding gets you to a challenging game. West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♠K, overtaken by South's ♠A. South returns a ♠ to North's ♠10, and he then plays the ♠Q.

You ruff the third ♠.

North plays low.

South ducks.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

With 2 tricks already gone you still have 4 losers. You could consider ruffing the 3 ♣ losers in dummy but that would just create a trump loser even when trumps are splitting 3-2. So it looks like you will have to establish the ♦ suit for discards. You could pull trumps and then play your ♦Q, hoping the defenders will grab their ♦A immediately. But unless they are real novices they will hold it up one round and you'll no longer be able to reach dummy.

The solution is to establish the ♦s before you use up dummy's ♥K.

Ruff the third ♠, then play ♦Q, (which they will duck), and another ♦, (which they will probably take). Win whatever they return, pull trumps ending in dummy, and enjoy your 3 ♦ winners.

If South does not take the second ♦ you continue the suit, and whether you ruff or discard a loser you still make the contract.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 7 5 ♥ J 7 ♦ A 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K 5	
♠ 4 3 2 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ K J 5 ♣ Q 10 7 4	N W E S	♠ K 10 8 6 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q 7 2 ♣ J 9 2
	♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q 10 5 4 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 8 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠6

South's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s, and his 2NT bid showed exactly 5 ♥s with an invitational strength hand. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠6, you play dummy's ♠9 and West contributes the ♠2.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The math is easy - you need 4 ♥ tricks. And you should be able to manage that by driving out the ♥A. But the defenders will probably hold up one or two rounds when you play on ♥s, so you must have an outside entry to dummy.

The ♠ Q J will provide that entry **IF** you make sure to win the first trick with your ♠A as an unblocking move. If you don't do so then East will be able to keep you out of the dummy and away from those good ♥s.

Suppose you allow dummy's ♠9 to hold the first trick, then start on ♥s. West will hold up the ♥A for 1 or 2 rounds. When he does win it he will return a ♠ and whether you play the ♠A or a low ♠ East will be able to prevent you from reaching dummy.

But if you win the first trick with the ♠A, then dummy's ♠ Q J will provide a guaranteed entry to the good ♥s.

Board 6
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 8 6 3 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 7 4	
♠ K J 4 ♥ Q J 10 5 3 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ A 10 5 ♥ 9 7 ♦ A K 6 3 ♣ A K 9 5
	♠ Q 9 7 2 ♥ K 6 4 ♦ 10 8 2 ♣ Q 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	Pass	1♦	Pass
1♥	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠2

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠2, you play dummy's ♠4 and North plays the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing just two more winners it looks straightforward to establish dummy's ♥ suit. Suppose you win the ♠10 and play the ♥9. If the defenders win this trick you are home free. You win their ♠ return with your ♠A, then continue ♥s to drive out their last stopper while you still have the ♠K as a dummy entry.

This won't work against good defenders, who will hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. Then when they continue ♠s you won't have another ♥ to return to dummy, so while you can use the ♠K as an entry to establish the ♥s you will never get back to use the good ones.

Instead you should win the first trick with your ♠A. Now when you attack ♥s a defensive holdup won't hurt you because you have **TWO** ♠ entries, the ♠J by a finesse and the ♠K.

South is almost certain to hold the ♠Q because his ♠2 opening lead promises an honor and the ♠Q is the only one you don't have.

So the ♠ finesse is an odds-on play to get a second dummy entry.